

*Meeting of the Aristotelian Society at 21, Gower Street, London,
W.C. 1, on Monday, January 19th, 1925, at 8 p.m.*

VI.—PICKWICKIAN SENSES.

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"DIFFLUENT, protopathic!" exclaims A.B.W. in a recent number of *The Times*, "I am baffled by these learned words, and would say, with all due respect to Vernon Lee (or Dr. Head) 'prythee, deliver thyself like a man of this world.'"

The old, old complaint! Philosophers, knowing the immense difficulties of combining accuracy of thought with man-of-this-world deliverance, may say—have said—confidently, that this reproach is, and always has been, absurd.

And yet, if Mr. Russell is right in saying* that the theory of relativity . . . has damaged the traditional notion of substance more than all the arguments of philosophers, how are philosophers to account for that? How is it that physics, with its cryptic other-world language, is more effective than philosophy?

If I may describe the jeopardy of philosophy somewhat bluntly, we have, on the one hand, an insistent demand (based on what must seem to most philosophers unwarrantable self-confidence) for speech that can be understood by men whose acquaintance (if any) with philosophy is only casual. On the other hand, we have what may be (unkindly) described as the futility of the bickerings of hair-splitting philosophers. And in contrast, we have the steady work of physicists, who, though

they do not by any means deliver themselves as men of this world, do manage somehow to move in some direction—making what is called remarkable progress; whereas the progress of philosophers appears (perhaps not only to the uninitiated) to be absorption in a more and more sophisticated word-juggling. And as this age (like Hobbes's) "countenances, if it does not encourage, a sawcie behaviour in men of low degree towards their betters," it can have even less use than most ages for men whose chief occupation seems to be to take word-juggling seriously.

It is, of course, easy to dismiss the whole matter by saying, as Butler did, that "all words are juggles. To call a thing a juggle of words is often a bigger juggle of words than the juggle it is intended to complain of. The question is whether it is a greater juggle than is generally considered fair trading."

But this does not satisfy me, even as a *homo lupsus*, let alone as a philosopher. For I see no reason for abandoning the supposition (accepted by Hobbes, for instance), that philosophers are primarily concerned with the consequences of words. And if the results of philosophic studies are—as they are often said to be—a jargon unintelligible to the general and bitterly questioned by philosophers themselves, is it not pertinent to ask whether an already parlous state of affairs may not be made worse by the adoption of such a novelty as the expression "Pickwickian Senses?"*

* The following is the source:—

"Mr. Blotton (of Aldgate), rose to order. Did the honourable Pickwickian allude to him? (Cries of 'Order,' 'Chair,' 'Yes,' 'No,' 'Go on,' 'Leave off,' etc.)

"Mr. Pickwick would not put up to be put down by clamour. He had alluded to the honourable gentleman. (Great excitement.)

"Mr. Blotton would only say then, that he repelled the hon. gent's

I am not sure that members of this society ever think of such worldly things as examinations. But even if they do not, I think it is only fair to the coming generation to face the fact that a new terror has been added to the austere pleasures of philosophy and that it is now possible for Professors to set the question: "What is meant by Pickwickian Senses?" And as I have no idea what the answer ought to be—and I dare say no one else has—I think we shall not be wasting our time if we decide, once and for all, what is the orthodox answer that students will have to give to get full marks. I will begin by suggesting what I think might be accepted as the answer. The

false and scurrilous accusation, with profound contempt. (Great cheering). The hon. gent. was a humbug. (Immense confusion, and loud cries of 'Chair' and 'Order.')

"Mr. A. Snodgrass rose to order. He threw himself upon the chair. (Hear.) He wished to know whether this disgraceful contest between two members of that club should be allowed to continue. (Hear, hear.)

"The Chairman was quite sure the hon. Pickwickian would withdraw the expression he had just made use of.

"Mr. Blotton, with all possible respect for the chair, was quite sure he would not.

"The Chairman felt it his imperative duty to demand of the honourable gentlemen, whether he had used the expression which had just escaped him in a common sense.

"Mr. Blotton had no hesitation in saying that he had not—he had used the word in its Pickwickian sense. (Hear, hear.) He was bound to acknowledge that, personally, he entertained the highest regard and esteem for the honourable gentleman; he had merely considered him a humbug in a Pickwickian point of view. (Hear, hear.) Mr. Pickwick felt much gratified by the fair, candid, and full explanation of his honourable friend. He begged it to be at once understood, that his own observations had been merely intended to bear a Pickwickian construction. (Cheers)."

The following is an example of Professor Broad's use of the phrase:—

"No doubt it is part of what we mean by a bit of matter that it shall, *in some sense*, have shape, size, and position. But in how literal a sense

discussion will, no doubt, produce other, better, answers. We can then choose.

Little attention seems to be paid by philosophers to grammar and its problems ; not many would boast of being more than gentlemanly grammarians. Nearly all work that deals with the relationship between words and thoughts and things soon develops into an exposition of subtle theories expressed in terms that become more and more involved. This in itself would be no drawback, for mere difficulty does not prevent consideration and acceptance. And though I see no reason for supposing that when men discuss science they are any less tenacious of their own point

must this be true ? We have already seen that, in some sense, an extension or a duration is composed of points or of instants respectively. But this sense is highly complicated and sophisticated, or, to use a happy phrase of Dr. G. E. Moore's, 'Pickwickian.' Now we shall doubtless be able to find Pickwickian senses in which there are entities that are at once public and extended. The question is : How Pickwickian may the term in our statement become before it ceases to be useful, and becomes merely misleading to say that we accept the existence of matter ? Our theological friends have much the same difficulties in their interpretations of the terms that are used in the Creeds. It could obviously only be true in a highly Pickwickian sense that the Second Person of the Trinity is the Son of the First. No one supposes it to be true in the literal sense in which *George V is the son of Edward VII* ; and the only substantial point at issue is whether the sense in which it might be true (assuming, for the sake of argument, that the Persons exist) is not so extremely Pickwickian that the statement is more likely to mislead than to enlighten. Fortunately for us, the terminology of our problem is not surrounded with the same emotional fringe as surrounds the terms used in Theology. It is no part of our duty to pay compliments to Matter, and so long as we state clearly what we do mean, it is of little importance whether our terms be used in a literal or in a highly Pickwickian sense. It will be a question of taste whether it shall be said that the theory that we finally adopt amounts to the acceptance or the denial of matter. If we should be accused of saying 'Matter is not Matter,' we shall at least be better off than Dr. F. R. Tennant, who labours under the dreadful imputation of teaching that 'Sin is not Sin.' " *Broad Scientific Thought*, pp. 233-4.

of view, than when they discuss philosophy, it is evident that, for some reason, scientists are more persuasive than philosophers. A student of mathematics or of science would usually feel quite happy if unexpectedly told that he was to be examined by another university instead of his own. How would the student of philosophy feel about it? And I am sure that the man in the street has a lurking feeling that although God Almighty would no doubt get full marks in any Mathematical or Science papers, He might come seriously to grief over Philosophy papers, if set by the wrong man.

Assuming then that there is this remarkable difference between Science and Philosophy, I venture to suggest that it is in no way due to the nature either of philosophers or their subject matter, but that it is entirely due to a failure to recognize that in using language, we are using something that has, as it were, a variable denomination, as money may have. If a man doing business in Germany chose to keep his books without taking into account the fact that marks had not the same value as pounds, he might argue that two always means two, and that two pounds are, in a highly Pickwickian sense, equal to two marks, but his accounts would present the characteristic features not only of the sabres given by the Indian to Vathek, but also of much philosophic writing. And the more subtle the reckoning became, the less would auditors be convinced of their correctness, and the more would the plain customer wonder what it all meant.

Now, just as a figure like 273 may mean 5460 in a different context (as it might in the case of pounds and gold marks), so also words change their meaning fundamentally and irreconcilably according to the "denomination" of their reference. The perplexing arguments about the nature of things, which have so long vexed philosophers, are largely due to the overlooking

of a change of denomination. For instance, if we start an argument about the universe, as we so often do, we shall in next to no time be wondering what is the matter with the other fellow's intelligence, as we so often do. We ignore the difference of denomination of the word "universe." The universe about which we, as scientists, know so much, is a "chocolate universe"; as the tutor of Monsieur de la Jeannotière and many other philosophers have assured us, it doesn't exist. For science consists essentially of a collection of commands which it has been found useful to assume that Nature obeys. This Nature is so remarkably obedient, because scientists take very great pains to issue only those commands which are likely to be obeyed, and to revise any that are disobeyed. On the other hand, all scientists deal as individuals with something so fundamentally different that no command whatever need be obeyed, every item being unique, and, at the best, only that unregenerate sinner, the exception that proves the rule.*

Before trying to state more clearly what I mean by the denominations of language, it will perhaps be best to anticipate the result to which my argument will lead. I suggest that the use of such a phrase as "Pickwickian Senses" proves that philosophy is still baffled by the riddle of language. Such a phrase is a subterfuge, a surrender, an esoteric appeal to faith. And my thesis is that scientific language can never be used significantly in any Pickwickian Sense; and that every deliverance of the man-of-this-world is, and must always be, delivered in a Pickwickian Sense. And I suggest that it is not yet the duty of philosophy to explain the results of combining these two denominations. It has first of all to state clearly what the difference is.

* Every philosopher should be made responsible for the feeding of a new-born baby for three months, in order to make him realise that the scientific "every baby" is only very remotely related to "this baby."

I am not sure how far my thesis is a novelty. So far as I am aware, no one has stated it quite in this way. The writer who seems to come nearest to my point of view is M. Paul Valéry in that very remarkable volume "*Variété*." Others have, I know, made statements that could be quoted in support. But it will be best, I think, to be satisfied with quoting a few passages from the pages of "*Variété*."

Towards the beginning of the volume (page 18) he speaks of "le désordre de notre Europe mentale," and asks "de quoi était fait ce désordre ? De la libre coexistence dans tous les esprits cultivés des idées les plus dissemblables, des principes de vie et de connaissance les plus opposés." I think you will admit that that is true.

On page 106, he describes a conversation he had with M. Fabre. "Nous cherchions à nous expliquer sur la poésie ; et quoique ce genre de conversation passe et repasse très aisément par l'infini, nous arrivions à ne pas nous perdre. C'est que nos pensées différentes, chacune se mouvant et se transformant dans son infranchissable domaine, parvenaient à se conserver une remarquable correspondance. Un vocabulaire commun,—le plus précis qui existe,—nous permettait à chaque instant de ne pas nous mésestimer."

The important point there is the clear distinction made between the "infranchissable domaine" (producing Pickwickian Senses) and the "remarquable correspondance" (where Pickwickian Senses are impossible).

On pages 149-50 he states the difference more clearly : "Nous trouverons donc en nous deux ordres de réponses à la sensation que j'ai décrite, et que nous donnent la vue du ciel et l'imagination de l'univers. Les unes seront spontanées, et les autres élaborées. Elles sont bien différentes, quoiqu'elles puissent se mêler et se combiner dans la même tête ; mais il faut les séparer pour

les définir. On les distingue souvent en attribuant les unes au cœur, les autres à l'esprit. Ces termes sont assez commodes." *

After stating on page 189 that "même notre pensée la plus 'profonde' est contenue dans les conditions invincibles qui font que toute pensée est 'superficielle,'" he describes man (referring specifically to Leonardo da Vinci) as follows: "Il voit comme nous et il voit comme soi. Il a un jugement de sa nature et un sentiment de son artifice. Il est absent et présent . . .

"La conscience . . . vient donc à soupçonner toute la réalité accoutumée de n'être qu'une solution, parmi bien d'autres, de problèmes universels. Elle s'assure que les choses pourraient être assez différentes de ce qu'elles sont, sans qu'elle-même fût très différente de ce qu'elle est. Elle ose considérer son 'corps' et son 'monde' comme des restrictions presque arbitraires imposées à l'étendue de sa fonction. Elle voit qu'elle répond, non à un monde, mais à quelque système de degré plus élevé dont les éléments soient des mondes. Elle est capable de plus de combinaisons internes qu'il n'en faut pour vivre; de plus de rigueur que toute occasion pratique n'en requiert et n'en supporte; elle se juge plus profonde que l'abîme même de la vie et de la mort animales; et ce regard sur sa condition ne peut réagir sur elle-même, tant elle s'est reculée et placée hors de tout, et tant elle s'est appliquée à ne jamais figurer dans quoi que ce soit qu'elle puisse concevoir ou se répondre. Ce n'est plus qu'un corps noir qui tout absorbe et ne rend rien

"Encore un peu, et elle ne compterait plus comme existences nécessaires que deux entités essentiellement inconnues: Soi

* Nous sentons dans un monde, nous pensons, nous nommons dans un autre; nous pouvons entre les deux établir une concordance, mais non combler l'intervalle. (M. Proust.)

et X. Toutes deux abstraites de tout, impliquées dans tout, impliquant tout. Egales et consubstantielles. . . .

“Le caractère de l’homme est la conscience ; et celui de la conscience, une perpétuelle exhaustion, un détachement sans repos et sans exception de tout ce qu’y paraît, quoi qui paraisse. Acte inépuisable, indépendant de la qualité comme de la quantité des choses apparues, et par lequel l’homme de l’esprit doit enfin se réduire sciemment à un refus indéfini d’être quoi que ce soit.”

I have quoted at some length—I hope not too fully—because these passages express in man-of-this-world deliverance what I now propose to express more technically.

It is generally assumed that it is sufficient to assert “*vel tu mihi aias vel neges.*” I suggest that it is necessary to add “*vel tu nobis aias vel neges,*” where “*nobis*” stands for some body of corporate opinion, such as Mathematics. The former represents language used by individuals—Pickwickian Senses: the latter, language used by bodies of specialists speaking in the name of some Science, and basing arguments on definitions. The former is based on the fundamental assumption “*nonnullus sum*”: the arguments of the latter are all based (as M. Valéry points out) on an imaginary zero about which is grouped everything relevant, “*nullum et cetera.*” The former might be expressed by “*sentio et sane sapio*”: the latter by “*sane sapio et sentio*”: and the “*sentio*” of the first refers to what is usually called “*reality.*” the “*sentio*” of the latter to the chocolate “*reality*” of such fictions as the average, the solar system or Euclidian space: and the “*sane*” of the former is common sense, the “*sane*” of the latter the logical implications of definitions. And the most conspicuous difference is perhaps most conveniently described as a difference of “*direction*”: the former being an inward looking towards the central individual, where the weight of the

argument and interest falls on the "et ego"; in the latter the direction is from the zero outwards, with the weight of the argument and interest on the "et cetera."

I base my contention on the fact that all knowledge is, so far as I can see, primarily a negation. We know by means of the differences between our "object" and another object used as a reference. What we know about "this" is that it differs in such and such ways from "that." Pushing our analysis to the utmost, we find ourselves with two ultimate criteria, namely: when we are taking a subjective view, our individual self, which is an ephemeral (though, for the individual, permanent) standard for negative knowledge: when we are taking what is known as a scientific view, a zero which serves as the basis of some scale and gives us that impersonal knowledge of how every thing differs --for convenience from any other thing but ultimately from nothing.

Thus my knowledge of another man may be of two kinds, and my language will always have to be interpreted accordingly; either I am judging the man as part of my personal universe and in that case he will have X as his characteristics; or I am judging him on some scale and he will then have Y as his characteristics. So also the number 11 as viewed from 10 must differ from 11 as viewed from 0.

It will generally be conceded that much of our thinking is egocentric; and that a considerable portion of the words used are meant to be interpreted in that sense. I suggest that it is to this thinking that the term "Pickwickian Senses" should be limited. It will be far less readily conceded that all scientific knowledge is (1) negative, *i.e.*, it tells what is not; (2) reference to a zero, *i.e.*, it must always have reference to a scale (using the word scale in the widest sense) of which the ultimate foundation is always NOTHING.

But worse heresies than this have in the past been advanced, derided and finally accepted. And I suggest that if Philosophy could once accept this (as it seems to me) fundamental distinction, we should no longer have to admit that our studies are what Dr. G. E. Moore says they are*: "But I am sorry to say that I have not yet reached the end of my explanations as to what my meaning is. I am afraid that the subject may seem tedious. I can assure you that I have found it excessively tedious to try to make my meaning clear to myself. I have constantly found that I was confusing one question with another, and that, where I had thought I had a good reason for some assertion, I had in reality no good reason. But I may perhaps remind you that this question, "How do we know so and so?" "What reason have we for believing it?" is one of which philosophy is full, and one to which the most various answers have been given. Philosophy largely consists in giving reasons: and the question what are good reasons for a particular conclusion and what are bad, is one upon which philosophers have disagreed as much as on any other question. For one and the same conclusion, different philosophers have given not only different, but incompatible reasons: and conversely different philosophers have maintained that one and the same fact is a reason for incompatible conclusions. We are apt, I think, sometimes to pay too little attention to this fact. . . .

"When I ask: What reason have *we* for believing in the existence of other people? a certain ambiguity is introduced by the use of the plural 'we.'"

Here Dr. Moore actually states the point which I am trying to emphasize. It is the ambiguity of "we" that shows the

difficulty most clearly.* Once recognize that when WE (one man) deliver ourselves (*i.e.*, one self) we always do so in Pickwickian Senses; and that when WE (mathematicians, etc.) deliver ourselves (*i.e.*, as representatives of an imaginary zero and its system) it is never in Pickwickian Senses—once we admit that, the way will be free for an analysis of the uses and the limitations of language, that may once more convince the world that philosophers are usefully concerned with the consequences of words.

* Darwin wrote: "When we reflect on the vast diversity of the plants and animals which have been cultivated and which have varied during all ages under the most different climates and treatment, I think we are driven to conclude . . ." Who or what is this we that reflects and is driven to conclude? The same question arises when *we* is called *IT*, *e.g.*, Weyl's translators (*Space, Time, Matter*) make him say: "Since the Human Mind first awakened from slumber, and was allowed to give itself free rein, it has never ceased to feel the profoundly mysterious nature of time consciousness"